a little hope and courage to reimagine their country as a place of togetherness, civility and tolerance.

For years, the BJP and the Prime Minister have referred to Rahul as ‘Pappu’—a nickname for a young boy or a man who is inept, introverted and innocent—thereby dismissing and infantilizing him in a manner loyally amplified by the media. They tried various smears during the Yatra too, dismissing it as a damp squib even before it began. But it was evident that Rahul was no spoilt scion of a dynasty. He walked the talk, hugged everyone warmly regardless of caste, religion or gender, and listened carefully to what they had to say. It is only in Modi’s India, with its toxic politics and celebration of the Mahatma’s assassin, that common decency, compassion and the upholding of the values of the Constitution can be seen as stupid.

One conversation I had with a group of women on the side of a road will remain with me forever. They had dressed up, worn their nice saris and stood patiently for the Yatra to arrive. I stopped to chat and soon was having a robust discussion about the reasons behind rising prices, how taxes work, why diesel cost so much and how international prices of oil were determined. This, coming from women whose faces were covered by their saris for modesty, was quite something. I asked one of them if she would consider standing for panchayat elections, and she lifted her veil and grinned at me, saying she had already been a pradhan. Her experience had clearly not just given her a voice, but also empowered all the women around her.

It was conversations such as this one and so many others that made the trip worth it. Walking 22 kilometres each day is a feat of endurance without a doubt—but this was no solitary hike in the mountains. The energy of people, present in the thousands at any given point, carries you along. Besides, I wore trainers—many walked in plastic chappals and even barefoot, which was humbling. More than anything, what startled me was the level of goodwill among the yatris themselves. In this mini India on the move, one encountered the qualities of accommodation, concern and friendliness even among strangers from different castes, religions and